to see him in connection with their affairs, but it was in the assembly hall that such audiences were to be held. Like other areas in the palace where interactions and decisions relating to state matters were made, this hall was to be separated from the inner apartments, the fear of violence being a constant threat. Indeed, 'everyone (in the palace) should live in his own quarters and not move to the quarters of another.'[15]

None of these anxieties feature in Ashoka's account of his administrative innovations. The informality outlined is so complete that one is tempted to imagine the king's eating and love-making interrupted by people with problems rushing in and out of his private chambers. The reality is likely to have been far less colourful, the access to the emperor careful and limited. The change would nonetheless have been seen as a new political culture in which the common weal required 'exertion and prompt dispatch of business [. . .] Whatever effort I make is made in order that I may discharge the debt which I owe to all living beings, that I may make them happy in this world, and that they may attain heaven in the next world.' The expressions here are uncannily and ironically similar to the extolling of the energetic king in the *Arthashastra*:

> In the happiness of the subjects lies the happiness of the king and in what is beneficial to the subjects his own benefit. What is dear to himself is not beneficial to the king, but what is dear to the subjects is beneficial (to him).
>
> Therefore, being ever active, the king should carry out the management of material well-being. The root of material well-being is activity, of material disaster its reverse.[16]

Such similarities are the consequence of historical retrospection. How do we make sense of them in the context of the third century BCE? It is entirely possible that Ashoka had imbibed the *Arthashastra*, its core having been composed earlier and its author very possibly living in the time of Ashoka's grandfather, and therefore known at least by repute down the decades. A ruler based in Pataliputra was in fact very unlikely not to have been familiar with the work, at least as a body of ideas. In tracing the genealogy of